External Factors Log

Project: LIHEAP energy assistance analysis, San Diego County
Study period: January 2018 – July 2025
This log records outside factors that may explain changes in LIHEAP enrollment during the study period. Rows marked **(Statewide context)** happened outside San Diego County but affected statewide rates, law or prices. Within each table, rows are in date order.

1. Economic indicators

Unemployment rate (California)

Factor	Dates / duration	Details	Source
Pre-pandemic lows	Jan 2018 – Feb 2020	Low of 4.0% (May–Oct 2019); 4.4% by Feb 2020.	CA WIOA State Plan
Pandemic spike	Mar – Apr 2020	Rose 11.7 points to a record 16.1%; about 3 million unemployed.	CA WIOA State Plan
Recovery	May 2020 – Aug 2022	Back to the pre-pandemic level by Mar 2022; record low of 3.8% in Jul–Aug 2022.	CA WIOA State Plan
Gradual rise	Sep 2022 – Dec 2023	4.7% by Sep 2023; 5.1% by Dec 2023.	CA WIOA State Plan; EDD
Plateau	Jan 2024 – Jul 2025	Held at 5.3–5.5%; 5.5% in Jul 2025.	EDD monthly releases

Inflation (San Diego area, CPI-U, change over 12 months)

Factor	Dates / duration	Details	Source
Pre-pandemic and early pandemic	2018 – 2020	*To be filled in from the BLS San Diego CPI-U series.*	BLS
Low inflation	Jan 2021	Prices rose 1.7% over the year.	BLS San Diego CPI, Jan 2021
High inflation	Jan 2022 – Jan 2023	8.2% over the year in Jan 2022; 6.4% in Jan 2023.	BLS San Diego CPI, Jan 2024
Cooling	Jan 2024	3.8% over the year.	BLS San Diego CPI, Jan 2024
End of study period	Jul 2025	4.0% over the year.	BLS San Diego CPI (history table)

Energy prices

Factor	Dates / duration	Details	Source
Long-run SDG&E electric rate growth	Jan 2014 – May 2025	SDG&E's bundled residential average rate rose 121% since Jan 2014, compared with 36% growth in consumer prices. Main drivers include wildfire mitigation spending.	CPUC Public Advocates Office, Jul 2025
Wholesale natural gas price spike (Statewide context)	Winter 2022 – 2023 (about Nov 2022 – Feb 2023)	California wholesale natural gas prices peaked at $49.52, more than 12 times the average monthly index price. Causes: below-normal winter temperatures, limited interstate pipeline capacity, reduced import capability, low storage levels, and volatile bidweek pricing. The CPUC found no evidence that PG&E, SoCalGas or SDG&E caused the spike.	SPURR summary of CPUC investigation
Energy prices fall after the spike	Jan 2023 – Jan 2024	San Diego energy prices fell 11.6% over the year, mostly because natural gas service prices dropped 59.1%.	BLS San Diego CPI, Jan 2024

2. Utility rate changes affecting energy burden

Factor	Dates / duration	Details	Source
SDG&E time-of-use pilot	Mar 2018	SDG&E moved about 120,000 residential customers onto time-of-use rates as a pilot ahead of the full rollout. Customers could opt out.	CPUC resolution on SDG&E TOU pilot
FERA discount increase	Jan 1, 2019	The Family Electric Rate Assistance discount, for households with incomes just above CARE limits, rose from 12% to 18%.	SDG&E 2020 FERA annual report
SDG&E time-of-use default	Mar 2019 – mid 2020	SDG&E moved residential customers onto the TOU-DR1 time-of-use rate at 700,000–1,000,000 customers per month. Customers could opt out	East County Magazine; CPUC decision on TOU timing

Factor	Dates / duration	Details	Source
		and return to tiered rates.	
SDG&E franchise agreements	Jun 2021	Gave SDG&E rights to use the city's public right of way for its gas and electric infrastructure. Added an energy cooperation agreement aligned with the city's Climate Action Plan. Required SDG&E to provide $30 million toward climate equity goals and to give the City Council regular updates on rates. Includes an exit clause letting the city void the agreement by a two-thirds vote if it decides to municipalize the grid.	City of San Diego
Water and wastewater rate adjustments (other utility)	Sep 2021 and Sep 2023	The City Council approved multi-year tiered rate increases for city-run water and sewer service. A standard utility allowance protects lower-income families facing combined utility burdens.	City of San Diego Public Utilities
San Diego Community Power enrollment	Feb – May 2022 (San Diego, Chula Vista, Encinitas, Imperial Beach, La Mesa); Apr 2023 (National City, unincorporated county)	Residential customers were automatically enrolled with San Diego Community Power, which replaced SDG&E as the electricity generation provider. SDG&E still delivers power and bills customers, who also pay a Power Charge Indifference Adjustment (PCIA).	SDCP rate transparency page
Income-graduated fixed charge adopted	Adopted May 15, 2024; billing began after the study period	CPUC Decision 24-05-028 added a monthly fixed charge based on income, paired with lower per-kWh rates. CARE customers pay about $6 per month, FERA customers about $12, and other customers $24.15.	CPUC resolution for SDG&E; CPUC CARE/FERA page
Power San Diego initiative rejected	Jun 2024	The San Diego City Council declined to place a Power San Diego ballot initiative on the ballot. The initiative would have replaced SDG&E with a	KPBS

Factor	Dates / duration	Details	Source
		nonprofit municipal electric utility.	
SDG&E 2024 General Rate Case	Decided Dec 19, 2024; retroactive to Jan 1, 2024; covers 2024 – 2027	The CPUC approved a 2024 revenue requirement $189 million (7.5%) above 2023, with yearly adjustments through 2027.	Sempra Form 8-K; CPUC fact sheet
California Climate Credit	Each year (2025: April and October)	A bill credit funded by the state's cap-and-trade program. Amounts and months change each year. In 2025, SDG&E residential customers received $81.38 on electric bills in April and October, plus $54 on gas bills.	NBC San Diego; CPUC Climate Credit history
Patz v. City of San Diego (other utility)	Jul 2025	A class action challenging the city's tiered residential water rates, which charged more per unit as usage rose. The city argued that high-volume users should pay more because they drive the infrastructure costs of peak demand. The trial court found that the tiered rates violated Proposition 218 of the California Constitution.	Best Best & Krieger

3. Housing market and eviction protections

Factor	Dates / duration	Details	Source
California Tenant Protection Act (AB 1482)	Jan 1, 2020 – Jan 1, 2030	Caps annual rent increases at 5% plus the change in cost of living, or 10%, whichever is lower. Also requires just cause to evict tenants who have lived in a unit for 12 months or more.	FHFCA AB 1482 FAQ
AB 3088 (COVID-19 Tenant Relief Act)	Signed Aug 31, 2020; covered rent due Mar 1, 2020 – Jan 31, 2021	Tenants who returned a COVID-19 financial distress declaration could not be evicted for rent missed from March to August 2020. For rent due Sep 2020 – Jan 2021, they were protected if they paid 25% of it by Jan 31, 2021. The unpaid rent remained	Greenberg Glusker

Factor	Dates / duration	Details	Source
		owed as ordinary debt, and landlords could not sue for it in small claims court before Mar 1, 2021.	
SB 91 (extension and rental assistance)	Jan 29, 2021; protections through Jun 30, 2021	**Eviction protection:** extended the AB 3088 protections. For rent missed Sep 2020 – Jun 2021, tenants were protected if they paid 25% by Jun 30, 2021. **Rental assistance:** $1.5 billion in federal funds for back rent, future rent, and utility and home energy costs, including arrears. Households below 50% of area median income came first. Landlords who took part received 80% of back rent as payment in full; if a landlord refused, the tenant could receive 25% directly.	SB 91 text (LegiScan)
SB 567 (stronger no-fault eviction rules)	Apr 1, 2024 – Jan 1, 2030	Closes loopholes in AB 1482 no-fault evictions. Owners evicting to move in must occupy the unit within 90 days and live there at least 12 months, or offer it back at the same rent and cover moving costs. Remodel and demolition evictions require permits and a detailed notice. Landlords who wrongfully evict or charge above the rent cap can owe up to triple damages, and the Attorney General and local government attorneys can enforce the law.	SB 567 text (LegiScan)
AB 12 (security deposit cap)	Jul 1, 2024	Caps security deposits, including pet deposits, at one month's rent. First month's rent is charged separately. Small landlords may charge up to two months' rent; a small landlord is a natural person, family trust, or LLC whose members are all natural persons, owning no more than two properties	CalMatters Digital Democracy

Factor	Dates / duration	Details	Source
		with four or fewer units in total.	
AB 2347 (eviction response time)	Jan 1, 2025	Gives tenants 10 days, up from 5, to respond after being served with an eviction lawsuit.	FirstService Residential
FEMA rental assistance, Los Angeles wildfires (Statewide context)	Jan 2025	Temporary grants for FEMA applicants whose homes were destroyed, covering a place to live during repairs or rebuilding, or help finding a new home.	LA County Recovery
HUD foreclosure relief, Los Angeles wildfires (Statewide context)	Mar 6, 2025	Extended HUD's foreclosure moratorium by 90 days for FHA-insured single-family mortgages in areas affected by the January 2025 wildfires.	HUD press release

4. Natural disasters and regional events

Factor	Dates / duration	Details	Source
Camp and Woolsey wildfires (Statewide context)	Nov 8 – 25, 2018	Insured losses estimated at $9–13 billion. The Camp Fire killed 85 people and destroyed about 18,800 structures; the Woolsey Fire killed 3 and destroyed about 1,600. Costs from these fires contributed to later wildfire charges on utility bills.	Moody's RMS; CAL FIRE incident records
Valley Fire	Sep 4 – 24, 2020	Destroyed 24 homes, 31 accessory structures, 6 RVs and 5 commercial structures. Evacuation orders and warnings affected 12,405 residents.	County after-action report
Tropical Storm Hilary	Aug 19 – 21, 2023	About 15,000 San Diego customers lost power. AccuWeather estimated $7–9 billion in damage and economic loss across Southern California.	CBS 8; AccuWeather
San Diego flood	Jan 21 – 23, 2024	4,856 structures across the county were damaged. FEMA approved $27	City of San Diego

Factor	Dates / duration	Details	Source
		million for residents' home and business damage. The city set up an emergency temporary lodging program; more than 300 people were still receiving support one year later.	
Los Angeles wildfires (Statewide context)	Jan 7 – 31, 2025	Property damage estimated at $28–53.8 billion. Businesses in the fire areas are estimated to lose $4.6–8.9 billion in economic output from 2025 to 2029; 1,863 businesses were affected.	LAEDC wildfire study